PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Mercedes-Benz Unimog U1300L (435)

1975–1993 · 435.115 · OM 352 / OM 366 · Lkw 2 t tmil gl

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Portal hub oil level**
  Owners call the portals the key weak point. Oil can migrate out of a hub, the left front especially, and starve the bearings. Pull the fill and drain plugs on all four, check the level and look for metal on the magnet. Budget for bearings and seals if you find either problem (Iain_U1250, Expedition Portal).

- [ ] **Breather pumping and diff overfill**
  On 6-lug trucks like the U1300, the front portal breather hose can pump hub oil into the differential. Owners report the same thing at the rear. If a differential is overfull and a hub is low, that's the cause. Ask whether separate breathers or a vent fix have been fitted (m37charlie, HUBB; Hodakaguy, Expedition Portal).

- [ ] **Gearbox**
  A bad transmission can cost as much as the truck (gdict, Steel Soldiers), though one UK owner quotes gearbox rebuilds at about £5,000 (Pictish, HUBB). Drive it through all eight gears and both directions, cold and hot, and listen for grinding or jumping out of gear. If it ever needs a tow, go gently: one owner notes the gearbox oil pump sits high in the case.

- [ ] **Which engine is fitted**
  Check whether it's the naturally aspirated 5.7 OM 352, the turbo OM 352A or the 6.0 OM 366/366A. Filters, injector nozzles, water pumps and manuals all differ. Repowers and replacement turbos are common, so read the engine plate rather than trusting the ad.

- [ ] **Military spec vs civilian**
  Ex-army trucks are 24-volt and basically trimmed, and ex-US Army Europe trucks were described as having no hydraulic system (Steel Soldiers). Check for any PTO, hydraulic or crawler-gear equipment you need. Contract plates help trace a military truck's history.

- [ ] **Paint and rust**
  BaT listings for 435s have shown bubbling at the windshield base and on tailgates and bed hinges. Look under the cab mats and at the bed floor too. A fresh green respray can hide a lot.

- [ ] **Air system and brakes**
  The brakes, front axle engagement and lockers all depend on compressed air. Make sure the system builds pressure quickly and holds it overnight, that both lockers engage and release, and that the air dryer cartridge isn't years old. Soft brake-pad compounds chatter less than the factory pads, according to Expedition Imports.

- [ ] **Weight and registration**
  If it's a camper, weigh it. Many builds exceed the 7,500 kg gross weight. Check how the title describes the truck (truck, motorhome or exempt vehicle) and how your state registers a 7.5-tonne air-braked import before you pay.

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- [ ] **Type number in the chassis number**
  The chassis number starts with the type: 435.115 is the U 1300 L, 435.117 the U 1300 L/37, 435.110 the U 1700, 435.111 the U 1700 L and 435.113 the U 1700 L/38. Early trucks read like 43511510...; later ones carry a 17-digit WDB4351151W... VIN.

- [ ] **Cab number plate**
  The 435 uses the 425-series cab, which carries a body-number plate reading 425.820. The 435 always has a full cab; a convertible cab points to a different series, such as the Turkish-built 436.

- [ ] **Engine**
  The naturally aspirated 5.7 OM 352 (catalogued as OM 353.959/.961) was standard. The turbo OM 352A and the 6.0 OM 366/366A followed, the OM 366 from 1987. Turbo engines take different injector nozzles, and naturally aspirated U1300Ls take their own water pump.

- [ ] **6-lug vs 10-lug axles**
  U 1300 Ls run 6-lug disc-brake axles with M18 x 1.5 studs. U 1700 types use 10-lug axles, which owners say don't have the 6-lug trucks' front breather pumping problem.

- [ ] **Military spec**
  Bundeswehr and US Army Europe trucks are 24-volt and basically trimmed, and some have no hydraulic system. Military contract plates let you trace a truck's service history.

NOTES

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